

The Gift

If you are reading this, then I am finally dead.

Perhaps it is you, my as yet unborn son, who are reading these words. Perhaps you have visited me from time to time in the long white wards of some gloomy asylum. Perhaps you will come with your mother. I'd like that. How many years will you have watched me grow toothless and wrinkled?

I am old now, that makes it easier. But I was like your mother once. Young and ravishing. Unscrupulous. I knew her for who she is the moment she put her hand in mine for me to read her palm. She gave me her hand, and I saw it all: the luxury of her clothes, the squalor of her one-room flat. The cracked mirror and the stain from the dripping tap, the shelf overflowing with expensive cosmetics. Years of reasoned choices.

She knew me even before she met me. She had done her homework, talked to all the right people. And she knew that I saw through her.

Tatiana.

Is that the name she goes by now? Her Russian accent is a silk dress that she slips into or out of as she pleases. What fashion will she be following by the time you read this?

It is not for her that I am about to do this. I have been planning it for years. She is just the catalyst, the trigger that makes it possible. We all have to pay our dues.

--X--

She was dining with friends at that table, there, when I first saw her. She seemed almost a child still, but her eyes were too deep for childhood. They were looking at me, audaciously. Then she turned away and laughed at some joke the young man beside her made. She touched his arm and said something privately to him. He moved his head as if to glance my way, then stopped and nodded and picked up the salt shaker, and spoke sideways to her, watching the salt tumble over itself as he turned the crystal shaker in his hand.

I had almost forgotten what it was like to excite the curiosity of a beautiful young woman. I spend so much time with those who have no illusions left.

I did not look up as her group began to leave. I focussed on the rich aftertaste of my coffee, and the article that I was writing. I suppose I was shielding myself from disappointment.

And then she was beside me, her coat on her shoulders, and she spoke my name. A mixture of timidity and excitement. I raised my head and was startled by her closeness. I could see the fine hairs on her cheek, could tell that she wore no perfume.

"Pavel tells me that you can see the future?" Her sentence ended like a purr.

"We can all see the future," I answered. "but most of us do not choose to. It tastes of vertigo. It is all too easy to lose your balance."

She sat down, uninvited, on the chair opposite me.

"Show me?" She held out her palm for me to read. I moved my chair closer, took her hand in mine. It was open and empty and upwards, and yet it felt as if she were gripping me like a rung that she must climb.

It wasn't her future that I saw. It was mine.

I could not tell her that. I could not meet her eyes.

Telling fortunes is an art. A bedside manner. There must be truth, but first there must be poetry. Truth without poetry is too brutal.

Those who seek my services do not control their lives. They come because their lives are disintegrating around them. They want me to protect them, they want a promise of escape. I cannot guide them all safely through the minefield of their lives. My failures line my brow and haunt my dreams. I have grown tired of the truth.

"I do not know your name," I said. "How can I read a stranger's palm?"

"Tatiana Vasilievna." She did not give her family name. I still do not know it. I do not know what name you will bear.

Nor do I read palms. I use the contact to test how hard my words hit home. I brush my fingertips along the lines, or use them to smooth back the fingers so that the hand opens up like a flower. To probe, to measure. To reassure.

Tatiana did not come to me to hear her fortune. She is one of those rare individuals who have their fortune all worked out. I haven't been so frightened since I was a teenager, closing my eyes for my first kiss.

"I hear money all around you," I said. "Other people's money. It chinks and falls away from them into the darkness, into a wishing well that keeps its own counsel."

Her friends gather round to listen. I long for privacy. Just me and her.

"Spinning lights, too bright. Harsh electronic sounds and soft music. There are men in the shadows behind you. The money is theirs. You are just the messenger."

Why say "You work as a cashier in a slot machine palace"? Where is the poetry in that?

"He's been stalking you, Tania!" one of the women jokes and the group giggles. A little nervously. Tatiana ignores them. I tighten my grip on her hand and look her straight in the face.

"You have a plan, but it will not work." I move down inside myself, just enough for the dizziness to start. I want to see if she can follow me. Just far enough to leave her friends behind. "I have a better plan," I tell her. "But you must trust me. And I must be able to trust you. Come back tomorrow. Alone."

Then I let her go, let her rise back up to the surface.

I am frail. I can hide the fact that I am gasping for breath with a cough. Tatiana clasps her hand to her breast and opens her mouth like a fish out of water. Her breath rasps.

"What's the matter?" her young man asks.

She does not answer, but nods slowly at me, pushing back her chair and standing up. Shakily.

"What did he do to you?" the young man insists, reaching out his arms for her, turning his head to glare at me.

She holds out her other hand, getting her balance, playing it down. "I'm all right," she says, leaving spaces between the words. "We'd better go."

"Mais il est fou !" another woman spits at me. "Loco!" She twists her open hand beside her head, a Latin gesture, emphasising my imagined insanity, threatening to strike.

"Let's go," Tatiana says to them, and moves the group away from me. A tight swarm of angry bees.

She leaves her chair askew, driftwood abandoned by the sea.

--X--

I needed a television, a stopwatch, an empty tin box, a teaspoon, pencil and paper.

I do not watch television. It dulls the senses. There is no smell, no taste, no touch. No aura and no trails.

The shop assistant treated me with patient condescension. I gave him a tip and my address. He came round after work to set the television up for me. I told him which channel I wanted, and that he should leave the sound off. He pointedly ignored the monastic richness of my rooms: the bare walls, the ancient wooden desk, the chair with delicately carved arms, the careful shelves of time-worn leather-covered books. With the portable antenna, the best reception was in the recess where my bed stands, behind the curtain that separates it from the rest of the room. I could not see it from my desk. I told him that suited me fine.

I warned Carlos in the restaurant that I was expecting someone. He barely nodded. He knows the routine. He knows that his physique and his discretion is what I hired him for. Following a silent waiter across the cobbled courtyard and up the sombre stairways creates just the right level of apprehension in my patrons.

--X--

Nine o'clock. Tatiana stood in the doorway, the darkened corridor behind her, even more vibrant than she had been the night before.

"I can do it!" she said excitedly. "The thing you did to me yesterday, I can do it!"

I ushered her in. I brushed her neck with the back of my fingers as I helped her off with her coat. A heavy coat, bought as much for its sturdiness as for its style. Standing behind her, I let myself drift back along the path that she had taken in from the street. She had not spoken to Carlos in the restaurant, she had come straight up. She had known exactly where she was going. No one knew she was here.

She sat down in my chair, and pulled it closer to the desk. Her bare arms rested on the red satin pads, the tips of her fingers on the desktop. She sat upright. I admired the determined set of her shoulders, the supple strength of her back. And then she twitched, uncannily, as if the film of her life had skipped a couple of frames.

A tremble rippled through her, then she turned to face me.

"You saw? Tell me that you saw!"

I stepped forward and laid my hands lightly on her shoulders. A calming gesture. A way to establish contact.

"I saw," I said. "I did not doubt you."

"So what is wrong with my plan? I just need to practice, no? And you, to help me."

"You did this at work?" I asked. "Everywhere in the casino, there are video cameras. Even in your office."

"I know," she said proudly. "The technician came down to check it. He said it was 'playing up'." The expression sounded foreign in her mouth. "But it was me who was playing up. I didn't tell."

"The casino is too dangerous. They already suspect you. If you do something now, they will not look for proof. They will fabricate it. Besides, you can do nothing when you slip out of time. You cannot move things, you can only observe. Come, let me show you something."

I handed her the stopwatch. I told her what we had to do.

"The lottery!" she exclaimed. "You can foretell the numbers in the lottery?"

Then it was time. I needed to be alone. She waited on my bed, behind the curtain, out of sight. The silent colours of the television threw strange shadows over her.

I sat at my desk, and held the teaspoon in my left hand over the edge of the desk. I took my pen in the other and conjured myself into a trance.

--X--

People ask me what the future holds for them. How can I answer? The future does not exist. Language is not capable of describing it. There is not one future but many. I can only speak by metaphor. Imagine a handful of sheep's wool, with no discernible shape or form. Attach the wool to a spindle and tease a

thread from it; the hairs in the wool begin to line up and make sense. The nearer the wool is to the spindle, the clearer the thread becomes.

Looking into the future is like finding meaning in an unspun ball of wool.

It is easy enough to follow a single strand. This table on which I write, for instance: I can follow it forward and back, from the tree that was butchered and sliced into planks, to the smoke and sparks that will spiral into the air on a still evening seventy-three years from now.

When a patron asks me to tell her future, I need to touch her in order to follow the thread. Almost immediately, it divides into a myriad of probabilities. Which to follow? Each successive fork weakens me. I cannot begin to enumerate the possibilities. So I make my patron talk, I make her show me what to look for. I make her choose now which paths she will and will not take. It is not I who tell her her future, it is she who tells me. As we speak, so the separate strands ravel or snap. A patron's fortune is a yarn we spin together.

The numbers for the next lottery belong to a thread that begins in the future. I have to swim, as it were, down the stream of time to reach them. That much is easy. Lottery ticket sales close an hour before the draw, but I do not need to go that far, not yet. Just enough to get the numbers before they are announced. 12, 16, 37, 41, 65, 68, 72. I snatch at the seventh number and turn upstream. Bringing the information back means struggling against the torrent. It leaves me washed out, emptied, beyond exhaustion. My eyes failing, I scribble the numbers on the notepad, and let the teaspoon fall from my fingers. I do not hear it clatter on the tin box.

--X--

Tatiana had carried me to the bed. Her bright aura filled the room: red, green and gold. I didn't need to open my eyes to see that.

"How long?" I whispered. "On the stopwatch, how long?"

"Three minutes, fourteen seconds." A twinge of annoyance. "The last number was wrong."

"It is not enough," I said. "We need seventy minutes: I cannot do that on my own. You must help. I must teach you to see."

--X--

It will be a year tomorrow. The best year of my life. The first time I have felt free. A peaceful meadow in the sun.

Now we are ready. She can slip out of time and keep sight of me as I move away. We have a sort of semaphore that she can see. I send her back the numbers, then she clings to my body, holding me fast in time until time catches up and I cough open my eyes.

We do not discuss what happens after tonight. She can see that as well as I. The jackpot is nineteen million. She will note the numbers and run down the stairs, across the cobbles, along the street. Seven months pregnant, in her

sensible shoes, to buy a lottery ticket. She knows that she must not stumble, that she must keep her eyes dry of tears. That when she lets go of me, I will start drifting, forever, always seventy minutes ahead of time.

Flotsam.

I will not be here when she comes back. She knows that she has just this one chance.

She is resilient. Like me, she will have a lifetime to work out how to pay her debt.

She has been good to me. She will be good to you. She knows that you carry the burden of my gift.